

Teachings of Buddha

- **His four noble truths** (Arya Satyas)
 - The world is full of sorrows (*Sabbam Dukkham*).
 - The cause of sorrow is desire (*Dwadesh Nidan/Pratitya Samutpada*).
 - If desires are conquered, all sorrows can be removed (*Nirvana*).
 - This can be achieved by following the 8-fold path (*Ashtangika Marga*).

The second truth, is based on Buddha's doctrine of Paticheha samutpada or Pratitya samutpada i.e. law of dependent origination or causation.

- **Eight-Fold Path** (Ashtangika marga)

i. Right understanding	ii. Right thought
iii. Right speech	iv. Right action
v. Right livelihood	vi. Right effort
vii. Right mindfulness	viii. Right concentration
- **Three Jewels** (Triratnas)

i. Buddha (the enlightened)	ii. Dhamma (doctrine)
iii. Sangha (order)	
- **Code of Conduct**
 - Do not convert the property of others
 - Do not commit violence
 - Do not use intoxicants
 - Do not speak a lie
 - Do not indulge in corrupt practices
- **Belief in Nirvana** Also known as *moksha* or salvation. It refers to belief in the concept of ultimate bliss, whereby the person gets freedom from the cycle of birth and death.
- **Belief in Ahimsa** Law of *Karma* and *Madhya Marga/Madhyama Pratipada* (the middle path).
- **Kutagorshala** It is a place where Buddhist monks discusses religious issues.

Division of Buddhism

The Buddhism was divided into following sects

- Hinayana or Lesser Wheel** The followers of Hinayana believed in the original teachings of Buddha. They believed in individual salvation. They do not believe in idol-worship.
- Mahayana or Greater Wheel** The follower of Mahayana sect believed in the heavenliness of Buddha and sought the salvation through the grace and help of Buddha and Bodhisattvas. It came into existence during the reign of Kanishka.
- Vajrayana or Vehicle of Thunderbolt** The followers of Vajrayana believed that salvation could be attained by acquiring the magical powers i.e. Vajra. The chief divinities of their sect were Taras. Vajrayana became popular in Eastern part of India, particularly in Bengal and Bihar.

Buddhist Texts

Tripitakas refers to Buddhists scriptures, it includes Vinaya Pitaka, Sutta Pitaka and Abhidhamma Pitaka.

- **Vinaya Pitaka** It contains the rules and regulations of monastic discipline for monks. An account of the life and teaching of the Buddha is also given.
- **Sutta Pitaka** Few discourses delivered by many Buddhist scholars like Sariputta, Ananda and others are given in it. It lays down the principles of Buddhism. It is a collection of Buddha's sermon and is divided into five groups.
- **Abhidhamma Pitaka** Having the philosophy of Buddha's teachings. It investigates mind and matter to help the understanding of things as they truly are
 - **Jatak Stories** It tells about 550 previous births of Buddha.
 - **Milindapanho** A conversation among Greco-Bactrian king, Menander and a Buddhist monk, Nagasena. It is written in the form of question and answer type.
 - **Kathavastu** It is hinayana granth. It is the first book written in Sanskrit language in Buddhist religion.
 - **Mahavibhashashastra** Written by Vasumitra, *encyclopedia* of Buddhist religion.
 - **Dipavamsa and Mahavamsa** In Pali language, it tells about the history of Sri Lanka.

Buddhist Councils

- **The First Council** (483 BC) It was held at Sattapanni (*Saptaparni*) cave near Rajagriha under the chairmanship of Mahakassapa. Here Vinaya Pitaka and Sutta Pitaka were compiled by Upali and Ananda respectively. Ajatashatru was the king at that time.
- **The Second Council** (383 BC) It was held at *Vaishali* during the reign of *Kalashoka*, the king of Shishunaga dynasty. The chairman was Sabakami. The monk of Vaishali wanted some changes in the rites. It resulted in division of sect into Sthavirvadins and Mahasamghikas.
- **The Third Council** (250 BC) It was held at *Pataliputra* during the reign of Ashoka (the Mauryan ruler). This council was held under the Presidentship of Mogaliputta Tissa, to revise the Buddhist texts.
- **The Fourth Council** (AD 72) It was held during the reign of *Kanishka* (the Kushana ruler) in Kashmir under the presidentship of Vasumitra and Ashwaghosha. Buddhism got divided into *Hinayana* and *Mahayana*.

Stupa and Vihara

- Stupas are doomed monuments containing relics of the Buddha. The stupas are carved with symbols of Buddha foot print, bodhi tree, vase.
- Viharas are monastery halls, which the monks would originally have used for study, solitary, meditation and communal worship.

MAGADHA EMPIRE

The period from 6th to 4th centuries BC saw the struggle for supremacy among four Mahajanapadas—Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa and Avanti. The founder of Magadha was Jarasandha and Brihadratha. But the growth started under the Haryankas. Magadha embraced the former districts of Patna, Gaya and parts of Shahabad and grew to be the leading state of the time.

Following are the causes for rise of Magadha

- Magadha became prominent under the leadership of Bimbisara of the Haryanka dynasty. Advantageous geographical location with both Rajgriha and Pataliputra situated at strategic locations.
- Abundance of natural resources, such as iron enabled Magadha rulers to equip with effective weapons. Use of elephants on large scale in war. The alluvial soil of the Gangetic valley and sufficient rainfall were very conducive for agriculture.

Haryanka Dynasty

Originally founded in 566 BC by the grandfather of Bimbisara, but actual foundation was laid by Bimbisara.

Bimbisara He was contemporary of Buddha. He conquered Anga (East-Bihar) to gain control over trade route with the Southern states. His capital was Rajgriha (Girivraja). He strengthened his position by matrimonial alliance with the ruling families of Kosala, Vaishali and Madra. His capital was surrounded by 5 hills, the openings in which were closed by stone walls on all sides. This made Rajgir impregnable.

Ajatsatru Son of Bimbisara, killed his father and seized the throne. Annexed Vaishali and Kosala (annexed Vaishali with the help of a war engine, which was used to throw stones.) Kosala was ruled by Prasenajit at that time. Buddha died during his reign; arranged the first Buddhist Council.

Udayin He founded the new capital at Pataliputra, situated at the confluence of the Ganga and Son.

Shishunaga Dynasty

- Founded by a minister Shishunaga. He was succeeded by Kalasoka (II Buddhist Council held during his period). Dynasty lasted for two generations only.
- Greatest achievement was the destruction of power of Avanti. Last Ruler was Nandivardhan.

Nanda Dynasty

- It is considered as first of the non-Kshatriya dynasties. Founder was Mahapadma Nanda. He added Kalinga to his empire. He claimed to be the ekarat, the sole sovereign who destroyed all the other ruling princes. Alexander attacked India in the reign of Dhana Nanda—the last ruler.

- Nandas were fabulously rich and enormously powerful. Maintained 200,000 infantry, 60,000 cavalry and 6,000 war elephants. This is supposed to have checked on Alexander's army from advancing towards Magadha.



ALEXANDER'S INVASION

- Alexander (356 BC–323 BC) was the son of Philip of Macedonia (Greece) who invaded India in 326 BC. At that time North-West India was split up into a number of small independent states like Taxila, Punjab (kingdom of Porus), Gandharas etc.
- Porus fought the famous Battle of Hydaspes (on bank of Jhelum) with Alexander. When Alexander reached Beas, his soldiers refused to go further, so he was forced to retreat.
- He erected 12 huge stone altars on the Northern bank of Beas to mark the farthest point of his advance. Remained in India for 19 months and died in 323 BC at Babylon.

The Mauryan Empire

The most immediate and unexpected by-product of Alexander's invasion of North-West was that it hastened the Mauryan conquest of the whole country.

Chandragupta Maurya (321–298 BC)

- The founder of the Mauryan empire was Chandragupta Maurya. He overthrew the last Nanda ruler, Dhanananda with the help of Kautilya also known as Chanakya.
- In 305 BC Chandragupta defeated Seleucus Nicator (the Greek ambassador), who surrendered a big territorial part to him including Kabul, Afghanistan, Baluchistan and Herat also received a Greek ambassador i.e. Megasthenes (wrote Indica having the description of Mauryan administration, society etc.)
- Chandragupta adopted Jainism and went to Sravanabelagola with Bhadrabahu where he died by Starvation (Sallekhana Santhara) at Chandragiri hill.

Bindusara (298–273 BC)

The son and successor of Chandragupta Maurya. Called **Amitraghata** (slayer of foes) by Greek writers. He is said to have conquered "the land between the two seas," i.e. the Arabian Sea and Bay of Bengal. At the time of his death, almost the entire sub-continent came under the Mauryan rule. Greek Ambassador, Deimachus visited the court sent by Antiochus.

Ashoka (273–232 BC)

- The son and successor of Bindusara. It is said that he became king by killing his 99 brothers. When he became the king, Radhagupta, a Minister of Bindusara also helped him.

- Under Ashoka the empire reached its Zenith. And in the history first time the entire Indian sub-continent came under a single umbrella (except extreme Southern India). He fought a battle known as Kalinga War in 261 BC in the 8th year of his coronation, in which one lakh people died.
- Ashoka sent peace missionaries inside India as well as abroad. Ashoka Dhamma was made up of tenets of most of famous sect of that time though tenets from Buddhism were predominant.
- Ashoka used his policy of Dhamma to promote religious tolerance in society. He also used Dhamma based policy to promote Buddhism in foreign land and Dhamma as a foreign policy to promote peace.
- A stone portrait of Emperor Ashoka has been found at Kanaganahalli. This is situated near Bhima river in Gulbarga district of Karnataka.

Ashoka's Edicts

Ashokan edicts are inscribed either on pillars of stone or on rocks. They consists of major and minor group. They give information on the life and reign of the king.

Major Rock Edicts

- They are a set of 14 inscriptions found at 8 places—Dhauli, Girnar, Jauguda, Kalsi, Mansehra, Shahbazgarhi, Sopara and Yerragudi.
- The major rock edicts also include two separate edicts found at Kalinga. They deal with administration and ethics.

Some Important Rock Edicts

Major Rock Edicts	Content
MRE I	Prohibition of animal sacrifice
MRE II	Refers to Cholas, Pandyas, Satya putras and Kerala putra (kingdom of South) and care for man and animals
MRE III	Liberality to Brahmins
MRE IV	Non-violence; courtesy to relations
MRE V	Appointment of Dhamma Mahamatras
MRE VII	Tolerance among all sects
MRE VIII	Dhammayatras
MRE IX	Charity, kinship, Dhamma
MRE XII	Religious tolerance
MRE XIII	Kalinga war; Bheri Ghosha to Dhamma Ghosha

Minor Rock Edicts

These are spread over 13 places i.e. Bairat, Brahmagiri, Gavimath, Gujarra, Jatinga-Rameshwar, Maski, Palkigunda, Maadagiri, Rupanath, Sasaram, Siddhapur, Suvarnagiri and Yerragudi. **Bhabru Inscriptions** is located at Bairat in Rajasthan and deals with Ashoka's conversion to Buddhism.

Major Pillar Edicts

These are a set of 7 edicts found at Allahabad, Meerut, Sopara, Lauriya Areraj, Lauriya Nandangarh and Rampurva. These edicts are engraved on Monolithic pillars. Kausambi edicts are known as Queen's Edict. They indicate about donations given by queen Karuvaki.

Minor Pillar Edicts

- **Rummindei Pillar Inscription** It mentions the exemption of Lumbini (birth place of Buddha) from tax.
- **Nigalisagar Pillar Inscription** It is located in Kapilvastu. It informs about Ashoka increasing the size of stupa of Buddha Konakamana to double of its former size.
- **Scheism Edict** It is located at Kausambi, Sanchi and Sarnath. It appeals for maintaining unity in Buddhist order.
- **Barabara Cave Inscriptions** It is located in Bihar. They speak about Ashoka's donation of cave to the Ajivikas.

Later Mauryas

According to Buddhist tradition, Ashoka ruled for 27 years. The disintegration of the Mauryan empire seemed to have set in immediately after Ashoka's death. The tenth and the last of the Mauryas was Brihadratha, who was murdered by his General Pushyamitra Shunga. This was the end of Mauryan dynasty.

Mauryan Administration

- The Mauryan state was a welfare state with highly Centralised Government. King was the Nucleus, assisted by Mantri Parishad, *which included*
 - Yuvaraj** The crown prince.
 - Gopa** The Purohit Chief Priest.
 - Senapati** Commander-in-Chief of army and other ministers.
- Coins of Mauryan Empire was called Pana and it was made up of silver and copper.
- The later Maurya's and Post Maurya Kingdom started votive inscription to record the religious offering made to institutions and land grants made to official or any other citizen.

Facts about Mauryans by Megasthenese

- According to Megasthenese, the administration of army was carried by a board of 30 officers divided into six committees, each consisting of five members. *They are as follow*
 - Army**
 - Cavalry**
 - Elephants**
 - Chariot**
 - Navy**
 - Transport.**
- Though, Megasthenese said that there was no slavery in India, yet according to Indian sources slavery was a recognised institution during Mauryans reign.
- Tamralipti in the Gangetic delta was the most prosperous part on the East coast of India.
- Megasthenese in his Indica had mentioned 7 castes in Mauryan society.

Art and Architecture

- *Mauryan art is classified into two groups*
 - Popular/Folk Art** Sculpture of Yaksha and Yakshini e.g. Yaksha of Parkham (Mathura), Yakshini from Vidisha (Madhya Pradesh) and Didarganj (Patna).
 - Royal/Court Art** Royal Palace of Chandragupta Maurya at Kumharar, Patna (Fa-hien referred it as the creation of God), city of Patliputra, Ashokan pillars, stupas and caves.
- Mauryans introduced stone masonry on large scale. Pillars represent the masterpiece of Mauryan sculpture, e.g.
 - Single lion capital at Rampurva and Lauriya Nandangarh.
 - Four lion capital at Sarnath and Sanchi.
 - Carved elephant at Dhauri and engraved elephant at Kalsi.
- **Stupas** were built throughout the empire to enshrine the relics of Buddha e.g. Sanchi and Bharhut.
- Varanasi was the best producer of silk.

POST MAURYAN PERIOD

Mauryans were succeeded by many ruling dynasties from Central Asia in North-West India and by native rulers (Sungas, Kanvas, Satavahanas) in the Eastern, Central and Deccan region of India.

The Shunga Dynasty (185 BC-73 BC)

- Pushyamitra founded this dynasty. His dominions extended to South as far as the Narmada river and included cities of Patliputra, Ayodhya and Vidisha.
- The fifth king was Bhagabhadra, to whose court Heliodorus, the Greek ambassador visited. A Shunga king, Agnimitra was the hero of Kalidasa's *Malavikagnimitram*.
- This period saw the revival of Bhagvatism. Patanjali's classic *Mahabhashya* was written during this time. The famous book on Hindu Law, *Manusmriti* was compiled during this period.

The Kanva Dynasty

The founder of this short-lived dynasty was Vasudeva, who killed the last Shunga king Devabhuti. They were swept away by Satavahanas of the Deccan.

The Satavahanas

- Founder of Satavahanas was Simuka. They were the successors of the Mauryans in the Deccan and the Central India. Important king was Gautamiputra Satakarni (AD 106-130) who raised the power and prestige of Satavahanas to greater heights. He set-up his capital at Paithan on the bank of river Godavari in Aurangabad district.

- First evidence of land grants to Brahmins was found (started by Satavahanas). Satavahanas built Nagarjuna Konda stupa and Amravati Stupa.
- Mostly issued lead coins (apart from copper and bronze). Acted as a bridge between North and South India. Satavahana rulers called themselves Brahmins. They performed Vedic rituals and worshipped Gods like *Krishna*, *Vasudeva* and others. However, they also promoted Buddhism by granting land to the monks.
- The two common religious constructions were the Buddhist temple that was called Chaitya and the monasteries, which was called *Vihara*. The most famous Chaitya is that of Karle in West Deccan.
- Their provinces were called Ahara, as it was in Ashoka's time. Their officials were known as amatyas and mahamatyas, as they were known in Mauryan times.

Chedis

- Chedis capital was Kalinganagara.
- The greatest and the most powerful king of the dynasty was **Kharvela**. His capital was Kalinganagara.
- The only source of information about the king Kharvela is the Hathigumpha inscription written in Prakrit language and Brahmi script. In the 9th year of his reign Kharvela built Mahaviyaya Prasad (*place of Great Victory*) on both the banks of the river Prachi, in order to commemorate his victories in the North.
- In the 13th year of his reign, Kharvela undertook many welfare schemes like building caves for the Jaina monks in the Udaigiri hills i.e. **Hathigumpha** and **Ranigumpha caves**.

Ikshavaku

The Ikshavaku dynasty was founded by the legendary king Ikshavaku. The important personalities belonging to this royal house are Bharata, Harish Chandra, Dilipa, Sagara, Raghu, Rama and Pashuadi.

Kingdoms After the Mauryas

The Indo-Greeks

- A number of invasions took place around 200 BC. The first to invade India were the Greeks, who were also called the Indo-Greeks or Bactrian Greeks (because they ruled Bactria).
- The most famous Indo-Greek ruler was Menander (165-145 BC), also known as Milinda. He had his capital at Sankala (modern Sialkot) in Punjab. He was converted to Buddhism by Nagasena or Nagarjuna (described in *Milindapanho* or the Question of Milinda). Greeks were the first to issue gold coins in India.

The Shakas or Scythians (90 BC)

- The Greeks were followed by the Sakas, who controlled a larger part of India than the Greeks did. There were 5 branches of the Shakas with their seats of power in different parts of India and Afghanistan.
- The most famous Shaka ruler in India was Rudradaman I (AD 130-150). He is famous for the repairs of Sudarshana lake in Kathiawar. His inscription was Junagarh inscription.
- A king of Ujjain, who called himself Vikramaditya defeated Shakas in 58 BC and started Vikram era (58 BC).

The Parthians/Pahalvas (AD 1st-3rd Century)

Originally, they lived in Iran, invaded at the beginning of Christian era, from where they moved to India. In comparison to Greeks and Shakas, they occupied only a small portion in North-West India in the 1st century. The most famous Parthian King was Gondophernes (AD 19-45), in whose reign St Thomas is said to have come to India for the propagation of Christianity.

The Kushans (AD 45)

- Came from North Central Asia near China. Their empire included a good part of Central Asia, a portion of Iran, a portion of Afghanistan, Pakistan and almost the whole of North India.
- Kanishka was the most famous king. *He patronised the following scholars*
 - **Ashvaghosha** (wrote *Buddhacharita*, which is the biography of Buddha and '*Sutralankar*'). Nagarjuna (wrote *Madhyamik Sutra*). Charaka (a physician, wrote *Charakhsamhita*).
- *Kanishka is known in history because of two reasons*
 - i. He started an era in AD 78, which is now known as Saka era and is used by the Government of India.
 - ii. He extended his whole-hearted patronage to Buddhism (held a Buddhist council in Kashmir). Some of the successors of Kanishka bore typical Indian names as Vasudeva.
- During Kanishka's rule, foreign trade flourished and it was at peak. Trade flourished through silk routes and oceanic routes. During Kanishka reign, Gandhara School of Art and Mathura School of Art flourished and developed.

Sangam Age (300 BC-AD 600)

The age of 3 Southern kingdoms Cheras, Pandyas, Cholas was known as **Sangam Age**. The word 'Sangam' means assembly. It was an assembly of Tamil poets and scholars.

The Three Sangam Kingdom

Kingdom	Capital	Royal Emblem
Cholas	Uraiyur later Puhar	Tiger
Cheras	Vanji or Karur	Bow
Pandyas	Madurai	Carp (fish)

The Pandyas

First mentioned by Megasthenese, who says that their kingdom was famous for pearls and was ruled by a woman. Their capital was Madurai. Important king was Nedunjelidan.

The Cholas

The kingdom was called Chola-mandalam or Coromandal. The chief centre was Uraiyur, a place famous for cotton trade. Capital was Kaveripattanam/Puhar. A Chola king named Elara conquered Sri Lanka and ruled it over for 50 years. Karikala was their famous king.

The Cheras

Their capital was Vanji (also called Kerala country). It owed its importance to trade with the Romans. The Romans set-up two regiments at Vanji to protect their interests. Greatest king was Senguttuvan, the Red Chera. Fought against the Cholas about AD 150.

Other Aspects of Sangam Age

All the gathered information is based on Sangam literature. Sangam was a college or assembly of Tamil poets held probably under Royal patronage (especially Pandyas). Silappadikaram by Ilango Adigal (story of a married couple) and Manimekalai by Sattanar are the famous epics of this time.

THE GUPTA PERIOD

After the decline of Mauryas, Guptas came into existence. Actually, we found two names related with Gupta dynasty, before Chandragupta I. These are Sri Gupta and Ghatotkacha.

Chandragupta I

He was the first prominent ruler of Gupta dynasty and assumed the title of Maharajadhiraja. He made his empire stronger by his own efforts and also by making marriage with Lichchavi princess. Lichchavis were a very powerful family or ruling class of Mithila at that time.

Samudragupta (AD 335-375)

- Samudragupta has been called the '**Indian Napoleon**' by **VA Smith** because of his extensive military conquests. He assumed the titles of *Vikramanka* and *Kaviraja*.
- Virasen was his commander-in-chief during Southern campaign. Vasubandhu, a famous Buddhist scholar was his minister.
- He subjugated 5 kingdoms in lower Bengal, upper Assam, Nepal and the territories farther West as well as number of republican clans.